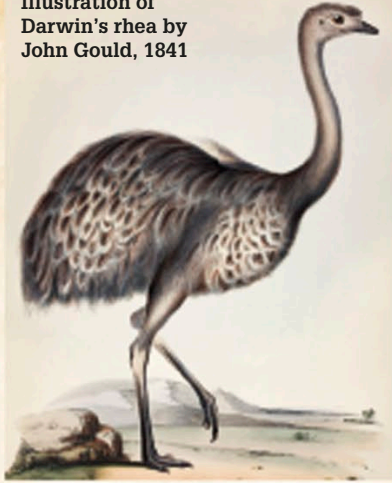


GREAT SCIENTISTS

Charles Darwin

Illustration of Darwin's rhea by John Gould, 1841



Darwin's rhea

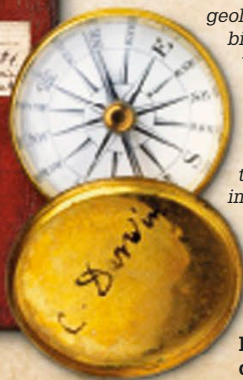
Named after the naturalist, this is the smaller of two species of rhea, a flightless bird, which Darwin encountered in South America. Darwin and his team, mistaking this rhea for a more common species, shot and ate the bird. Only after did Darwin realize it was the rarer type and preserved the remaining specimens.

“... we are not here concerned with hopes or fears, only with the truth as far as our reason permits us to discover it...”

Charles Darwin,
The Descent of Man



One of Darwin's notebooks



Darwin's compass

The young naturalist

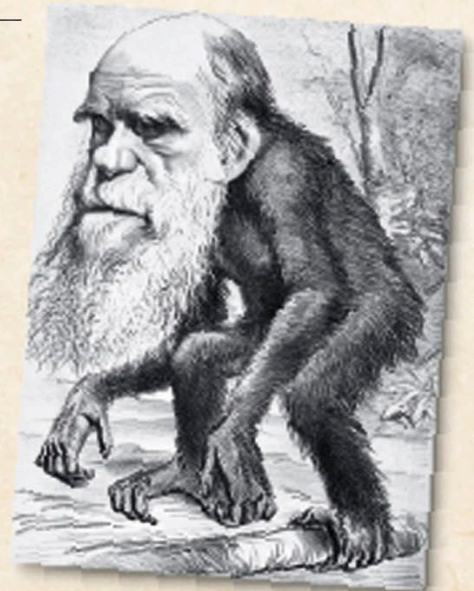
Darwin discovered his love of natural history at Cambridge, where he spent much of his time collecting beetles. He graduated in 1831 and accepted a place as a naturalist on board HMS *Beagle*. The ship's five-year voyage proved to be the most important period in Darwin's life, providing the basis for his future ideas and writings.

Revolutionary idea

On his return to England in 1836, Darwin published an account of his travels, which made him famous. He married, settled at Down House in Kent, and had ten children. Over the years he began to develop his theory of natural selection—the process in which living things with characteristics suited to their environment survive and produce offspring with similar features. He published his revolutionary book *On the Origin of Species* in 1859. This was followed by *The Descent of Man* in 1871, in which he applied his ideas to explaining the evolution of humans.

Around-the-world trip

During his five-year voyage on HMS *Beagle*, Darwin filled dozens of notebooks with his observations on animals, plants, and geology. He collected thousands of bird specimens, many of which were identified back in England by the ornithologist (someone who studies birds) and illustrator, John Gould. The material Darwin gathered on the Galápagos Islands was very important in shaping his ideas.



Controversial theory

Although many scientists at the time agreed with Darwin's theory of evolution, others were more sceptical. His ideas were violently opposed by traditional Christians, and Darwin was ridiculed for supposedly implying that humans were descended from monkeys. This cartoon appeared in a magazine after the publication of *The Descent of Man* in 1871.